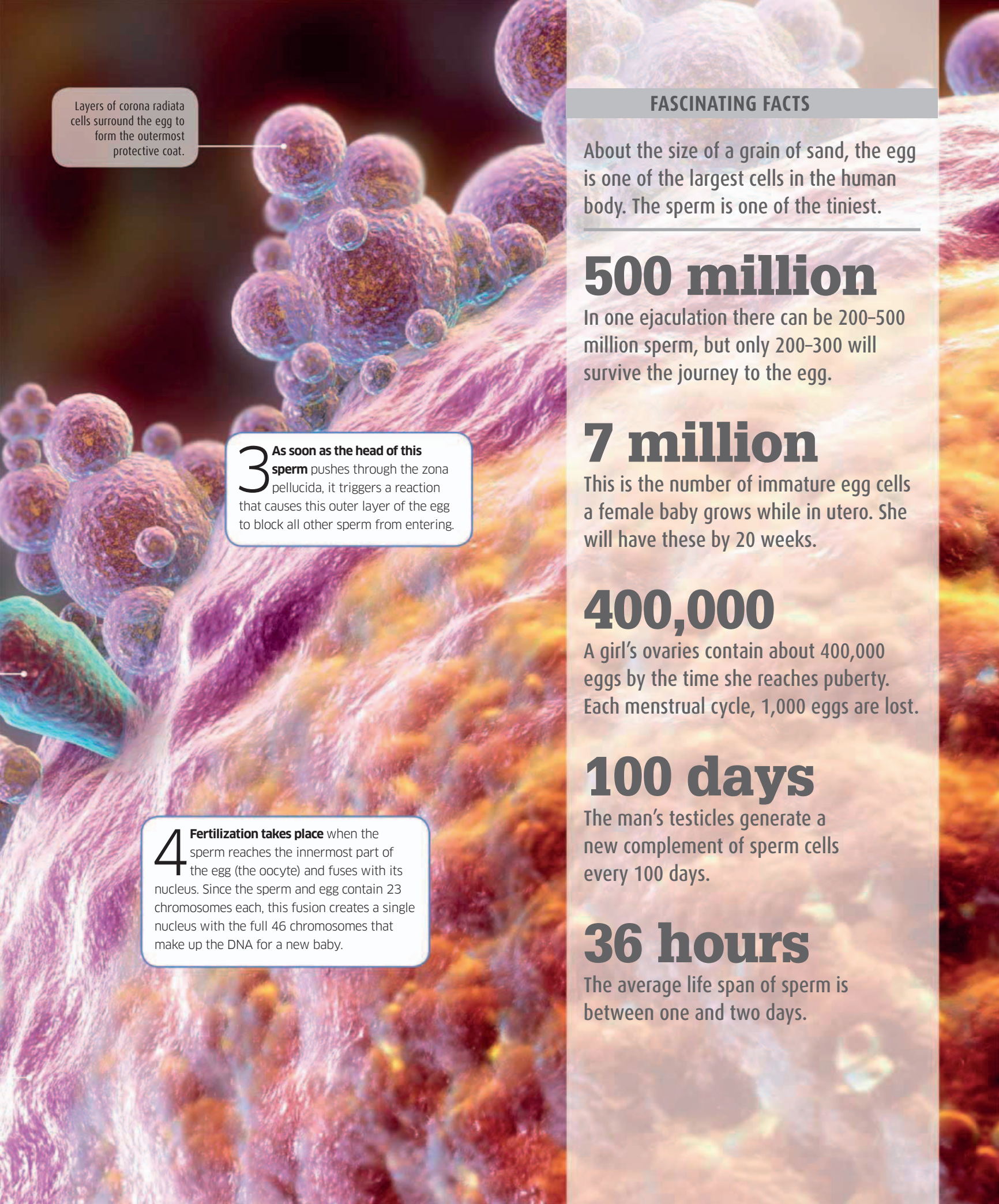




Layers of corona radiata cells surround the egg to form the outermost protective coat.

3 As soon as the head of this sperm pushes through the zona pellucida, it triggers a reaction that causes this outer layer of the egg to block all other sperm from entering.

4 Fertilization takes place when the sperm reaches the innermost part of the egg (the oocyte) and fuses with its nucleus. Since the sperm and egg contain 23 chromosomes each, this fusion creates a single nucleus with the full 46 chromosomes that make up the DNA for a new baby.

FASCINATING FACTS

About the size of a grain of sand, the egg is one of the largest cells in the human body. The sperm is one of the tiniest.

500 million

In one ejaculation there can be 200–500 million sperm, but only 200–300 will survive the journey to the egg.

7 million

This is the number of immature egg cells a female baby grows while in utero. She will have these by 20 weeks.

400,000

A girl's ovaries contain about 400,000 eggs by the time she reaches puberty. Each menstrual cycle, 1,000 eggs are lost.

100 days

The man's testicles generate a new complement of sperm cells every 100 days.

36 hours

The average life span of sperm is between one and two days.